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*The Left Hand of
Darkness*

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Truth is a matter of the imagination.
The soundest fact may fail or prevail in
the style of its telling: like that singular
organic jewel of our seas, which grows
brighter as one woman wears it and, worn
by another, dulls and goes to dust. Facts
are no more solid, coherent, round and
real than pearls are. But both are sensitive.

— Gently Ai

On the fickle nature of "Truth".

King in his own eyes is Kharide

— Prime Minister Estraven

To a king, or rather a madman, his country is not its people, its culture, or its struggles. It is nothing but himself: his pride and his power. The nation is the king's ego: every wound to it is a wound to him, every praise of it is praise of him. Every judgment of the nation is a judgment of the king.

When I say patriotism. I mean fear.
The fear of the other. And its expressions are political, not poetical: hate, rivalry, aggression. It grows in us that fear. It grows in us year by year.

— Prime minister Estraven

progress is less important than presence.

To exhibit the perfect uselessness of the knowing the answer to the wrong question

— Faxe

On the planet Winter, the Handdarata is one of the two major religions, the other one being the Yomeshta. The cornerstone belief of the Handdarata is that one should strive towards ignorance, while the Yomeshta hold that all of time was seen at once by Meshe, and so all is already known, all is light. Despite the pursuit of ignorance, the Handdarata follow the mystical ritual of foretelling. The ritual has primarily the asker and the foretellers: the asker gets to ask one question, usually at a high material cost and often an even higher personal cost. It seems funny that the religion of ignorance has the ability to foretell the future so exactly. The foretellings seldom bring the solace the asker sought; rather, their lives are further worsened by knowing than by unknowing. It goes to show the value of ignorance to human existence, and the futility of chasing certainty, for a life fully known is death.

Ignorance is a ground of thought.
Unproof is the ground of action.

— Faxe

Faxe: What is known? What is
sure. predictable, inevitable-the
one certain thing you know con-
cerning your future and mine ?

Genly Ai: That we shall die.

Faxe: ... The only thing that makes life
possible is permanent, intolerable uncer-
tainty: not knowing what comes next.

Burden and privilege are shared
out equally; everybody has the
same risk to run choice to make.
Therefore nobody here is quite as
free as a free male anywhere else.

-A comment made on the androgynous society of Winter.

There is no division of humanity into strong
and weak halves, protective/protected, dom-
inant/submissive, owner/chattel, active/pas-
sive. In fact the whole the whole tendency to
dualism that pervades human thinking may be
found to be lessened or changed, on Winter.

Commentary on the androgynous society of Winter.

Hainish postulate that continuous sexual capacity and organized social aggression, neither of which are attributes of any mammal but man, are cause and effect? Or, like Tumass Song Angot, did they consider war to be a purely masculine displacement-activity, a vast Rape, and therefore in their experiment eliminate the masculinity that rapes and the femininity that is raped?

The stranger who comes unknown is a guest. Your enemy is your neighbour.

Compare the torrent and the glacier.
Both get where they are going.

He wanted his hearers to be frightened and angry. His themes were not pride and love at all, though he used the words perpetually; as he used them they meant self-praise and hate. He talked a great deal about Truth also, for he was, he said, “cutting down beneath the veneer of civilization.”

Thoughts of Estraven on a speech given by the new prime minister who was responsible for his exile.

... Of course there is no veneer, the process is one of growth, and primitiveness and civilization are degrees of the same thing. If civilization has an opposite, it is war. Of those two things, you have either one, or the other. Not both.

To oppose something is to maintain it.

— Estraven
